could he have followed any other path than the one he was on now? Just like she had no other choice but to be here. The scent of tobacco and leather lingered between them. After he lit his candle, he returned the lighter to his pocket, closed his eyes and mumbled a prayer.

They sat side by side on the bench, both lost in their thoughts—his likely about his brother and Rose's about her mother. She sometimes couldn't recall Maman's face; it had been three years, and so many details had begun to fade. After she and Léa were gone, there would be no one else to remember her mother and all the moments of their life together—pitting cherries to make *clafoutis*, fishing on the banks of the Loire, sewing her first dress under her mother's watchful gaze—it would all vanish without a trace.

"Felix was my best friend," he said. "We used to fish together in the Müglitz." His hand drifted in the air. "He'd always catch the biggest brown trout, but he'd tell Papa I'd caught it."

"Maman taught me to fish on the Loire. The salmon and trout swam too fast for us, but we caught plenty of pike. We would make *quenelles*."

"Dumplings." He smiled. "How did you make them?"

"We mixed the pike with eggs and flour, rolled them into balls, poached them briefly and then poured a *béchamel* sauce over them before baking." Rose puckered her lips, touching her thumb and index finger to her mouth.

"Sounds delicious."

"It—"

The church bells rang out. When they ceased, an awkward silence fell. He leaned forward and blew out the candles, staring at the smoke entangled in the air.

"You and me," he said, in a strange tone.

"What?"

"Nothing." His voice shifted.

She stood to take her leave. "I must—"

"Show me your *Arbeitsbuch*." His voice sharpened into a command.

She inwardly balked at his mood change, but handed him her work pass.

"Rose Cotillard," he said, tapping the permit against the thick white knuckles on his other hand. "Which factory do you work at?"

"Archimedes."

"I am Kriminalinspektor Kurt Reinhardt, and I will speak with the